JESUS CHRIST & HIS EVERLASTING GOSPEL

REL A 250 - Winter Semester 2026

Section 003 – M/W 9:00-9:50am 2006 LSB
Section 005 – M/W 10:00-10:50am 2006 LSB
Section 020 – T/Th 9:00-9:50am 2107 JKB
Section 023 – T/Th 10:00-10:50am 2107 JKB
Section 025 – T/Th 12:00-12:50pm 2107 JKB
Section 039 – T/Th 2:00-2:50pm 2102 LSB

Professor: Dr. Hank R. Smith Office: 316H JSB Email: hank_smith@byu.edu

Last name: A-G	TA: Alex Cazier	Phone: 256-520-6006	Email: acaz04@byu.edu
Last name: H-O	TA: Ava Olsen	Phone: 949-402-9444	Email: avaolsen@byu.edu
Last name: P-Z	TA: Kaitlyn Everett	Phone: 801-971-0074	Email: everekai@byu.edu

Please contact your TA for <u>all</u> questions regarding assignments, tests, scores, late work, etc. She will inform me when necessary. Do not reply to her LearningSuite emails. She can only respond if you email her at the correct email listed above. You are going to love your TAs!

BRIGHAM YOUNG UNIVERSITY – RELIGIOUS EDUCATION

Course Overview and Objective:
Religion A 250 is an introductory course designed to engage university students in a **<u>serious study</u>** of the scriptural witnesses regarding Jesus Christ as the Son of God, the Savior of the world, and the central figure of the Plan of Salvation.

1) **Spiritually Strengthening:** We aim to deepen faith in the Lord Jesus Christ and in His restored Church. A close study of the scriptures creates an opportunity for the Holy Ghost to provide direct teaching, revelation, comfort, and strength.

2) **Intellectually Enlarging:** Students will gain a greater understanding regarding the history of the Bible, along with its narrative, doctrines, and teachings. Students will also develop skills enabling them to read the scriptures in context.

3) **Character Building:** A serious study of the Lord Jesus Christ, along with a concerted effort to consistently apply His truth, will create a mighty change in our nature. As we yield to the Spirit we can become saints through the Atonement of Jesus Christ.

4) **Lifelong Learning and Service:** This course will introduce students to various resources designed to enhance lifelong study of the Savior and His Gospel.

COURSE REQUIREMENTS
Grades are based on scores from the following components, each of which is explained later in the syllabus:

1. Daily reading / Attendance / Ratings	500 pts
2. What Think Ye of Christ Paper or Project	100 pts
3. Exam 1, Exam 2, & Final Exam	<u>400 pts</u>
Total	1000 pts

1. Daily Reading / Attendance / Journal / Ratings (400 pts):

When we finish our last class of the week, you have at least three days before the 11:59 pm (midnight) deadline the following Sunday night to report scores for reading and journal entries. If you miss the deadline for reporting or uploading a journal, you can still upload to Learning Suite, but you will only receive ½ credit, so please report before or on Sunday. Please do not ask for exceptions on late work. Professor reserves the right to not pass any students who misreport their work.

Daily Reading: Students are expected to study 15+ minutes each day in the assigned readings (see class schedule). Students will report reading on LearningSuite. Assign how many points you honestly deserve based on the time you spent studying each day. For instance, if you read 15 minutes each day most days, then give yourself 75% of points for that reading. Similarly, if you didn't read 15 minutes each day, deduct points accordingly. The greatest spiritual experiences you will have will take place outside of class during your individual reading as you seriously, and prayerfully, study the scriptures themselves.

Attendance: Active mental participation in class is essential to succeeding in this course. Attendance will be taken in class. I trust you to be honest in assigning how many points you truly deserve for each class. If you generally arrive on time, don't leave early, stay awake, stay focused, stay off social media, and participate as appropriate then give yourself full points. If you do not attend, arrive late, leave early, do homework, sleep, scroll through social media, shop, or do things that negatively affected your true attendance subtract points accordingly. Professor reserves the right to not pass any student missing more than 5 class sessions or any student who misrepresents their attendance. Except for BYU sponsored activities or in extreme circumstances, attendance points cannot be made up.

Journal: To encourage personal application, students are expected to keep a scripture journal. Full credit can be earned by writing at least 600 words per week. This can be in one sitting or in multiple entries throughout the week. Journals should describe principles you identified in the assigned readings and how they can be applied in daily life. Quoting scriptures should not be considered part of the word count. Students may type or hand-write their entries. Photographs of hand-written journal entries can be uploaded. Journals for the previous week are expected to be uploaded to LearningSuite by the following Sunday at 11:59pm (midnight).

Ratings: Students will receive points for completing both mid-semester and final student ratings.

"**What Think Ye of Christ" Paper or Project (100 pts):** See rubric on the last two pages of the syllabus. To increase doctrinal understanding, students will prepare a written analysis of scriptural passages about the Savior and those who have chosen to follow Him. Instructions are on the grading rubric which is part of the syllabus. If you choose, instead of a paper, you can do a 12-hour project focused on the Savior. Papers and projects will be graded by either TAs or Dr. Smith.

Exam 1 (120 pts), Exam 2 (120 pts), Final Exam (160 pts): All exams will be available through the testing center. Exams are closed book/note and will be multiple choice, true/false, short answer, and essay with material emphasizing the storyline, doctrines, and principles from the readings and class discussions. Exams will not address personal application of principles of the New Testament. You are responsible to know the testing center's hours (see testing.byu.edu). Taking tests outside of the testing center or before/after the scheduled days is not allowed. If a student does not pass the final exam (60% or above) the professor reserves the right to withhold credit for the class.

A 930-1000 pts	A- 900-929	B+ 870-899	B 830-869	B- 800-829
C+ 770-799	C 730-769	C- 700-729	D+ 670-699	D 630-669
D- 600-629	E 599 & Below			

GRADING: Students will receive a grade according to the **exact points** earned, no matter how near a grade border. Please do not ask for an exception or for extra work.

DATE	Reading/Journal Assignments	
Jan 7/8	First day of class Between January 7th – April 22nd: Study the Assigned Readings 15+ minutes <u>every</u> day	
Week 1 Jan 12-18	Moses 1-5	Complete Syllabus Quiz *Write around 600 about words in your scripture journal this week about what you learned about Christ and His Gospel*
Complete Weekly Report 1 and upload Journal Entries on LS before Sunday evening at midnight		
Week 2 Jan 19-25	Recorded Lecture on LS	*Write around 600 about words in your scripture journal this week about what you learned about Christ and His Gospel* **No classes on Monday*
Complete Weekly Report 2 and upload Journal Entries on LS before Sunday evening at midnight		
Week 3 Jan 26-Feb 1	Mark 1-11, Matthew 1-13	*Write around 600 about words in your scripture journal this week about what you learned about Christ and His Gospel*
Complete Weekly Report 3 and upload Journal Entries on LS before Sunday evening at midnight		
Week 4 Feb 2-8	Matthew 14-20	*Write around 600 about words in your scripture journal this week about what you learned about Christ and His Gospel* **No class on Monday* *(Monday students may attend on Tuesday or get the recording on LS)*
Complete Weekly Report 4 and upload Journal Entries on LS before Sunday evening at midnight		
Week 5 Feb 9-15	Luke 1-10	*Write around 600 about words in your scripture journal this week about what you learned about Christ and His Gospel* **Wed & Thurs classes will be a recorded lecture on LearningSuite*
Complete Weekly Report 5 and upload Journal Entries on LS before Sunday evening at midnight		
EXAM 1 available at Testing Center: Feb 12-17 (Late Day – Feb 17, fee required)		
Week 6 Feb 16-22	Luke 11-18	*Write around 600 about words in your scripture journal this week about what you learned about Christ and His Gospel* **No class Monday / Tuesday is Monday Schedule*
Complete Weekly Report 6 and upload Journal Entries on LS before Sunday evening at midnight		
Week 7 Feb 23-Mar 1	John 1-12	*Write around 600 about words in your scripture journal this week about what you learned about Christ and His Gospel* **Tues & Wed classes will be a recorded lecture*
Complete Weekly Report 7 and upload Journal Entries on LS before Sunday evening at midnight		
Week 8 Mar 2-8	Matthew 21-23; Mark 11-12; Luke 19-20	*Write around 600 about words in your scripture journal this week about what you learned about Christ and His Gospel*
Complete Weekly Report 8 and upload Journal Entries on LS before Sunday evening at midnight		

Week 9 Mar 9-15	Matthew 24-25; Mark 13-14; Luke 21**;** John 13-17	*Write around 600 about words in your scripture journal this week about what you learned about Christ and His Gospel*
Complete Weekly Report 9 and upload Journal Entries on LS before Sunday evening at midnight		
EXAM 2 available at Testing Center: Mar 10-13 (Late Day – Mar 13, fee required)		
Week 10 Mar 16-22	Matthew 26-27; Mark 15 Luke 22-23; John 18-19 Recorded Lecture on LS	*Write around 600 about words in your scripture journal this week about what you learned about Christ and His Gospel* **No class on Monday* *(Monday students may attend on Tuesday or get the recording on LS)*
Complete Weekly Report 10 and upload Journal Entries on LS before Sunday evening at midnight		
Week 11 Mar 23-29	Mark 16; Matt 28; Luke 24; John 20-21	*Write around 600 about words in your scripture journal this week about what you learned about Christ and His Gospel*
Complete Weekly Report 11 and upload Journal Entries on LS before Sunday evening at midnight		
"What Think Ye of Christ" Paper <u>or</u> Project Due by 11:59pm MDT on Friday, April 3		
Week 12 Mar 30-Apr 5	3 Nephi 11, 22; Acts 1-5, 9, 22; Romans 1, 5-6, 8; 2 Tim 1-4	*Write around 600 about words in your scripture journal this week about what you learned about Christ and His Gospel*
Complete Weekly Report 12 and upload Journal Entry on LS before Sunday evening at midnight		
Week 13 Apr 6-12	Revelation 1, 4-5, 12, 19-22 **Learning Suite:** Nicene Creed article – Dr. Lincoln Blumell	*Write around 600 about words in your scripture journal this week about what you learned about Christ and His Gospel*
Complete Weekly Report 13 and upload Journal Entry on LS before Sunday evening at midnight		
Week 14 Apr 13-19	The Reformation before the Restoration	*Write around 600 about words in your scripture journal this week about what you learned about Christ and His Gospel* **No class on Thursday*
Complete Weekly Report 14 and upload Journal Entry on LS before Sunday evening at midnight		
FINAL EXAM available in Richards Building during Finals: Apr 17-22 (No late day)		

Other Items:

<u>Late Assignments</u>

While I am sympathetic, it is your responsibility to manage the demands, pressures, and difficulties of your life and still meet deadlines. Please do not use these as excuses for not turning work in on time and still expecting to receive full credit. I only make exceptions for full credit late work based on extreme circumstances, such as unexpected personal hospitalization (or that of a spouse or child), death/funeral of an immediate family member, or a university documented reason. All other late work will be scored as outlined in this syllabus.

Class Structure and Procedures

Class will begin by singing one verse of a hymn and a prayer offered by a student (any student who desires not to pray please let me know privately). We will then have brief announcements. The majority of class will be dedicated to understanding the context and content of the Savior's life and teachings and identifying doctrines and principles we can know and apply.

Use of Technology

You are more than welcome to use your laptop/tablet/phone for scriptures, to take notes, and enhance your learning as long as it is not used for distracting purposes (social media, web browsing, etc.) or distracting to others. If you are continually distracted because of another's use of technology please report it to me and I will consult privately with those involved and discuss potential grade implications of distracting behavior.

Artificial intelligence (AI) language models, such as ChatGPT, are examples of online learning support platforms: they cannot be used for course assignments except as explicitly authorized by the instructor.

Honesty and Integrity

All students are expected to abide by BYU's Honor Code, which includes academic honesty. Inflating self-reported grades, fabricating assignments, cheating, discussing exams, or plagiarism are each violations of the Honor Code. Those who display dishonest behavior will be subject to the options outlined by the University. All course materials (including outlines, handouts, syllabi, exams, quizzes, PowerPoint presentations, as well as lecture audio and/or video recordings, etc.) are proprietary. Students are prohibited from posting or making available for others to post or otherwise distribute course-related materials, including notes, to any websites or shared online resources (including Google Drive, OneDrive, Quizlet, etc.). To do so is a violation of the BYU Honor Code.

University Policies

The Honor Code and other University policies regarding students with disabilities, discrimination, harassment, and classroom disruption can be read and reviewed at http://religion.byu.edu/students.html#policies . If you have a qualified, documented medical situation that affects your assignments and/or test-taking please contact the University Accessibility Center (801-422-2767) and provide me with the appropriate documentation.

Office Hours

I love to meet with my students. Come up before or after class and make an appointment.

Statement on Belonging

We are united by our common primary identity as children of God (Acts 17:29; Psalm 82:6) and our commitment to the truths of the restored gospel of Jesus Christ (BYU Mission Statement). We strive to create a community of belonging composed of students, faculty, and staff whose hearts are knit together in love (Mosiah 18:21) where:

- *All relationships reflect devout love of God and a loving, genuine concern for the welfare of our neighbor (BYU Mission Statement);*
- *We value and embrace the variety of individual characteristics, life experiences and circumstances, perspectives, talents, and gifts of each member of the community and the richness and strength they bring to our community (1 Corinthians 12:12–27);*
- *Our interactions create and support an environment of belonging (Ephesians 2:19); and*
- *The full realization of each student's divine potential is our central focus (BYU Mission Statement).*

Final Thought

Please know the TAs and I care about your learning, faith, and life and want you to succeed. Let us know how we might be of help to you. I look forward to a great experience studying the Savior's life and teachings with you.

"What Think Ye of Christ" Paper

Purpose: To analyze the pre-mortal, mortal, and post-mortal ministry of the Savior and your own personal commitment to Him.

Instructions: Jesus Christ is the most significant being to ever live on this planet. Using scriptural text, appropriate quotes and experiences from other Christians (both members of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-Day Saints, as well as non-members of the Church), and your own personal commentary, you are to describe and explore how He has impacted the world and each individual to have ever lived or who will ever live. Similarly, you are to explain how Christ has impacted (or not impacted) your unique circumstances, family and friends, and overall purpose.

1. *Scriptural Text:* Discuss which scriptural texts best describe the character and message and mission of Christ. Describe the context of each passage. What do you love about these particular passages?

2. *Christians:* Discuss the men and women (you may discuss members of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-Day Saints, and/or those not of our faith) who have displayed loyalty and love to Christ. How did they show their commitment to Christ? How did they come to know Him? How did they describe their experience with Him?

3. *Application:* Bridge the gap between the scriptural text, the Christians you chose and your life today. How have the scriptural passages you chose and other Christians influenced you personally? What do you think of Christ? What is your commitment to Him? Use appropriate personal experiences to explain your relationship with Christ.

4. *Style Guide / Format:* The paper is due **Friday, April 3rd at 11:59pm MDT**. It should be well organized and represent original, high quality, university level writing (spelling, mechanics, style etc.). Your paper should be written in first person and should be at least **10 pages** (double spaced) in length (Times New Roman, 12 pt font, 1-inch margins) – submitted as a *pdf or docx* through Turnitin on LearningSuite. Late papers turned in within 24 hours will be given half credit. Papers turned in after 24 hours late will not be graded.

   Optional: Attach your paper to your family history file using FamilySearch Memories App

Scoring Rubric

FACTORS TO BE CONSIDERED	3	4	5	COMMENTS
Scriptural Text				
Christians				
Application				
Style Guide / Format				
Total	_____			X 5 = _____ / 100
GRADING SCALE 3 = Needs work – Quality of work did not satisfy a college level expectation or fulfill the assignment 4 = Satisfactory – Quality of work met all the objectives of the assignment 5 = Excellent – Quality of work deserves recognition				

"What Think Ye of Christ" Project

Purpose: To analyze the pre-mortal, mortal, and post-mortal ministry of the Savior and your own personal commitment to Him.

Instructions: Jesus Christ is the most significant being to ever live on this planet. Using scriptural text as your basis, you are to create an **original piece** which describes and explores how the Savior's pre-mortal, mortal, and post-mortal ministry has impacted the world and each individual to have ever lived or who will ever live. Similarly, you are to show how Christ has impacted (or not impacted) your unique circumstances, family and friends, and overall purpose.

You will plan out and diligently work on a project of your choosing. Don't do a project to get out of writing a paper. In general, students who have chosen to do projects tell me they took significantly more time to finish them than they would have if they'd written a paper. This project is purposely left open so that you can exercise your agency and choose a project that you are motivated to work on that will cause you to seek inspiration, stretch your mind, use and develop your skills, and grow. *If you are not passionate about it, then you picked the wrong project. Choose a new project or write a paper instead.*

Throughout the process, you should be creating a great, usable, tangible product that represents your work. Your TAs and I do not want to give too many specific ideas about what should or shouldn't be done so as not to bias your thinking, but past projects have ranged from research reports, scholarly book reviews, writing, art, film, music, computer programs, apps, virtual reality, games, etc. The sky is the limit. It should be clearly evident that you did indeed put in the amount of time and effort that you are reporting. For a general reference, projects should take 12+ hours to complete.